# SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

**Analyzing How Reachable and Effective Victim Aid Programs are in Rural Areas**

A Thesis Proposal Presented To
The Faculty of
College of Criminal Justice Education
In Partial Requirements for the Degree
**BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN CRIMINOLOGY**


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# CHAPTER 1

# THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

## 1.1 Background of the study

Victim aid programs are crucial for offering immediate and long-term support to those who have faced crime, abuse, violence, or natural disasters. These programs typically provide services such as legal assistance, psychological counseling, medical care, temporary housing, and financial aid. However, many rural areas struggle with limited access to these services due to geographic isolation, insufficient resources, and systemic neglect. Programs that are available in rural settings may not offer the same range of services as those in urban areas, limiting their ability to address the comprehensive needs of victims. Despite these challenges, some rural victim aid programs have been successful in providing immediate support through community-based initiatives that leverage local resources and networks (Mitchell, 2019).

Many studies globally have pointed out the obstacles rural populations face in accessing victim support services. For example, in countries such as Canada and the United States, researchers have observed that victims in rural communities often face challenges, including long travel distances, limited public transportation, scarce service providers, and concerns about confidentiality. According to Logan, Evans, and Leukefeld (2004), rural victims of domestic violence frequently delay seeking help due to fear of social stigma and inadequate legal support. Similarly, Wendt and Hornosty (2010) found that in rural Australia, deeply rooted patriarchal

norms and underfunded services further limit access to victim aid. These international studies underscore the need for targeted strategies and funding to support rural victims effectively.

In the Philippines, most studies and interventions regarding victim aid services have focused on urban areas, especially Metro Manila and other major cities. Existing literature often zeroes in on specific issues, such as gender-based violence, child protection, and trafficking, with government agencies and NGOs offering various forms of assistance. However, there is a lack of data and Research specifically dedicated to rural communities. Studies that address rural areas often generalize their findings or overlook the unique cultural, economic, and logistical challenges that are specific to these areas. This creates a significant gap in understanding how effective and accessible these programs really are in remote provinces and communities. Without data tailored to rural areas, policies and aid programs may not adequately address the real needs of these populations.

This study aims to fill the gap in the literature and practice by analyzing the reachability and effectiveness of victim aid programs in rural areas. The Research will explore the availability of services, the awareness and use of these programs by victims, and the challenges faced by both aid providers and recipients. Key issues to be examined include poor infrastructure, insufficient staff, limited governmental presence, and cultural factors that discourage victims from seeking help. The study's objectives are to identify the primary barriers to access, assess the quality and responsiveness of existing services, and provide practical recommendations to enhance the delivery of victim aid in rural settings.

This study is important because it aims to reveal a hidden truth or fact of rural communities where victims might suffer in silence due to a lack of support. By providing data and analysis, the study can serve as a valuable resource for policymakers, government agencies, NGOs, and community leaders who strive to create inclusive and fair victim support systems. Improving the reach and effectiveness of these programs in rural areas can lead to a more just and compassionate society, one that protects all individuals regardless of their location. Ultimately, this Research aims to empower rural victims by advocating for systems that respond effectively to their unique situations.

**1.2 Conceptual Framework**

According to the study by Akter & Shakil (2020), titled "Effectiveness of Victim Support Services: A Study on Victim Support Center in Dhaka," Victim Support was first established in 1972 in Bristol and became a registered charity in 1974. It was underway because there was little to no help available for crime victims. It is discouraging to note that people from all walks of society, irrespective of their age, sex, color, ethnicity, occupation, race, and religion, are becoming victims of such a shocking social threat. Particularly, the women and children of the people are increasingly becoming victims of crime, including violence, trafficking, acid burn, sexual harassment, and rape, because of the patriarchal attitude, religious sentiment, and traditional male-led attitude.

The causes of victimization, it violent or nonviolent, are among the most stressful human experiences. Therefore, ensuring quality of life for victims of crime is a key challenge facing policymakers and mental health providers. The Victim Support Service is committed to enhancing the rights and needs of victims who have suffered harm from crime. The impact of crime on the people affected by it can be rooted. Victims may undergo physical, mental, and financial damage, from which some may not ever recover. Victim support services can effectively handle a victim's needs and provide support, counseling, shelter, legal aid, medical treatment, and protection from further harm. Victim support services help victims recover from their loss and return to a normal life like others. Victim support services should, among other things, provide victims with emotional, social, and material support free of charge, efficiently address their problems, offer them the necessary information about their rights and available services, and ensure that their services are confidential.

Additionally, this study is grounded in Social Support Theory, which emphasizes the crucial role of emotional, informational, and instrumental support systems in promoting individual well-being, particularly during periods of stress or crisis. According to this theory, individuals who experience trauma, whether from criminal victimization or natural disasters, are more likely to recover and regain stability when they receive timely and appropriate social support from family, peers, community networks, and institutions. In the context of rural areas, victims often face compounded challenges, including geographic isolation, limited access to healthcare, legal services, and psychological support, as well as slower emergency response

times. Social Support Theory offers a lens for examining how structured victim aid programs can serve as organized support networks that compensate for these deficits.

**1.3 Review of Related Literature**

**Accessing rural victim assistance**

AICS Program | DSWD - Assistance to Individuals in Crisis Situations (n.d.) The Department of Social Welfare and Development (DSWD) in the Philippines implements a range of social protection programs designed to assist individuals and families in times of crisis. One of its core initiatives is the Assistance to Individuals in Crisis Situations (AICS), which provides immediate support, such as financial, medical, burial, transportation, food, and educational aid, to those affected by emergencies or personal crises. Complementing this is the Emergency Cash Transfer (ECT), which provides unconditional financial assistance to families affected by natural disasters to support their recovery.

In addition, Victim assistance programs typically offer services in three general areas: counseling and support, legal assistance, and public awareness and legislative reform. Counseling and support are perhaps the most common functions, helping victims to cope with posttraumatic stress disorder, rape trauma syndrome, and other conditions caused by an assault. Individual and group counseling, crisis intervention, medical referrals, and relocation services are some of the resources typically available. Programs also provide legal assistance to crime victims

who are testifying, seeking restraining orders, or otherwise involved in the criminal justice system. Services include orientation to the justice system and courtroom assistance. Finally, victim assistance services act as advocates for crime victims, generally raising public awareness of specific crimes and how to prevent them, and advocating for legislative reforms. ( Victim Assistance Programs | Research Starters | EBSCO Research n.d.)

Moreover, Lynch & Logan (2022) examined rural versus urban/suburban victim service professionals' perceptions of the impact of the pandemic on the occurrence of gender-based violence and vulnerable populations within their communities, challenges faced by victims, and advice for victims sheltering in place with an abuser. The results yielded several key findings that warrant deeper discussion and highlight the need to consider community context when developing coordinated interventions to serve victims of gender-based violence during and after the pandemic. Furthermore, this study provides initial information that victim service agencies can use to build emergency planning strategies in times of crisis involving the social and physical isolation of victims.

According to the survey of DSWD, it shows that DSWD programs, including AKAP, AICS, and Walang Gutom Program, are perceived by beneficiaries to have improved financial stability among the lower social classes. While this suggests some awareness among the public/beneficiaries, it does *not* isolate knowledge among victims of crises (accidents, disasters, abuse) or measure how many are aware of *all* available assistance types. (Survey: DSWD Programs Improve Indigent Filipinos' Financial Stability | Philippine News Agency n.d.)

According to Kelly et al. (2022), it is essential to advertise that the victim is not at fault, that they won't be a burden to others, and that the victim's thoughts and feelings are important. Making information more accessible in public places may give the person the opportunity to gather the courage to seek help. Use a range of media to raise awareness of the services available to victims (examples include social media, Radio, and Print media) and distribute brochures in commonly visited places (examples include doctors' offices, MCH facilities, or even shops) so that victims can be aware of these programs.

**Stakeholder perceptions of effectiveness**

According to Taylor et al. (2021). The effectiveness of victim aid programs in rural areas is often compromised by a lack of resources, insufficient funding, and difficulty in retaining qualified personnel. Programs that are available in rural settings may not offer the same range of services as those in urban areas, limiting their ability to address the comprehensive needs of victims. Despite these challenges, some rural victim aid programs have been successful in providing immediate support through community-based initiatives that leverage local resources and networks.

Additionally, Mitchell (2019) supported that to enhance the accessibility and effectiveness of victim aid programs in rural areas, several recommendations have been proposed, including increasing community-based outreach, improving transportation options, and strengthening local partnerships between service providers. Tailoring services to the specific

needs of rural victims and integrating digital technologies to overcome remote support barriers are also identified as effective strategies for overcoming geographic barriers.

Moreover, Rajesh Kumar (2024). Stated that the effectiveness of legal aid services for domestic violence victims in rural Uttar Pradesh is significantly hampered by a range of socio-cultural and institutional barriers. These barriers not only limit victims' access to justice but also perpetuate the cycle of abuse by reinforcing existing power dynamics and deterring women from seeking help.

Additionally, Tugano et al. (2019). Stated that the collaboration between the Municipal Social Welfare and Development Office (MSWDO) and Barangay VAWC Desks is generally effective in terms of referral and monitoring. This highlights that successful reach in rural settings often depends on strong vertical collaboration and systematic referral systems from the smallest unit (Barangay) to the municipal level.

According to Clark & Moore (2015) . Government policies and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) play a crucial role in supporting rural victim aid programs. However, the effectiveness of these initiatives is often hindered by inadequate funding, limited governmental involvement, and logistical challenges in reaching rural communities. Government policies aimed at improving service delivery in rural areas are often inconsistent, and funding for victim aid programs is typically lower in rural areas compared to urban regions.

Moreover, Akter & Shakil (2020) stated that a wide range of services is provided to victims, including emergency shelter and immediate support, healthcare, legal advice and support, psychological advice and counseling, training and capacity building for the rehabilitation of victims, and support for reintegration into their family and community. Victim Support Center receives victims with honor and dignity, listens to the victims and finds out their problems, and ensures a proper environment with a view to providing information to repressed women and children.

**Rural victims experienes**

According to Osuagwu & Vines (2025). The challenges faced by rural (DV) Domestic Violence service providers including access barriers, burnout, and systemic limitations. Despite these challenges, participants demonstrated commitment and a willingness to improve service delivery. Effective strategies must include culturally competent and trauma-informed approaches, targeted mental health support for providers, and enhanced access through mobile and telehealth services. Addressing these areas is essential for enhancing trust and outcomes for vulnerable populations. Importantly, future policy and Research must reflect the diversity of rural Australian communities to ensure reforms are inclusive and impactful.

In addition, Gillespie et al. (2021) stated that the latter have focused on crime victim service providers' (VSPs') perceptions regarding clients' needs and barriers, as well as perceptions of service provision, needs, and barriers related to their agency's operations.

Although relatively small, the body of provider-focused victim services research has commonly considered the influence of rurality on service provision. The present study adds to this body of Research by examining reported needs and barriers of VSPs (*N* = 94) in a Mountain West state, considering the influence of rurality and concentrated need.

In addition, Chen et al. (2018) demonstrated that rural residents have limited access to and use of online health information compared to their urban counterparts, particularly in terms of accessing high-speed Internet. They also have lower access to health care providers. Given that people identify healthcare professionals and the Internet as their primary sources of health information, these infrastructure limitations may pose significant obstacles to accessing and using health information in rural areas. However, less is known about the differences in access to and use of health information sources between rural and urban residents.

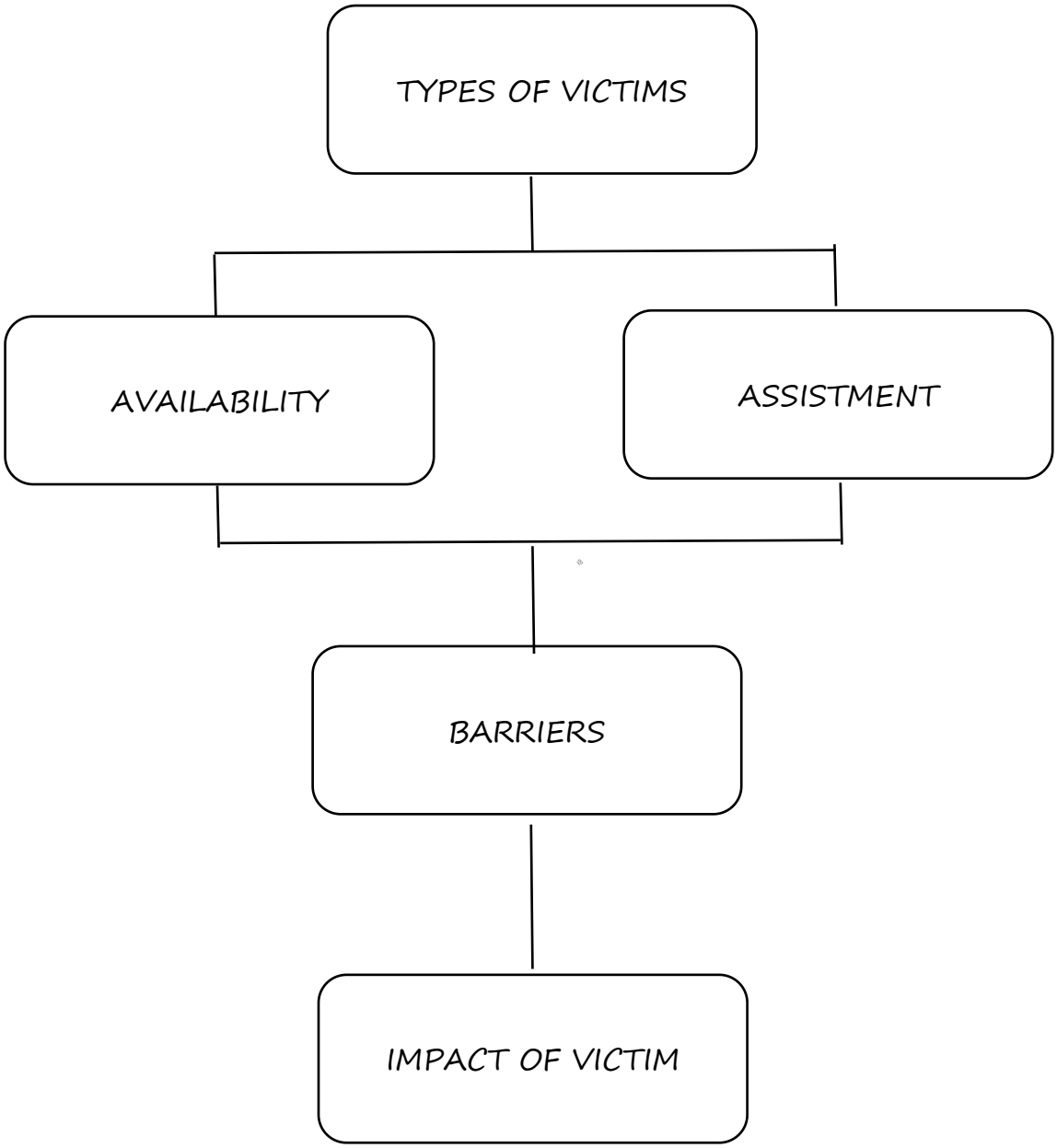
Moreover, Kelly et al. (2022) stated that isolation and a lack of support and resources were common barriers. Participants noted 'being alone and not knowing anyone in the area' and 'not wanting to be a burden on others' as barriers in rural towns. Financial difficulties, poor mental health, and not having the time and energy to seek support mean that some people delay accessing services.

**Rural context and program delivery**

DSWD's ManCom Greenlights Amendments to Guidelines of AICS, Other Key Agency Programs | Crisis Intervention Program | Department of Social Welfare and Development

(n.d.).In an effort to make its programs and services more responsive to the evolving needs of its clients, the Department of Social Welfare and Development's (DSWD) management committee (MANCOM) conditionally approved the proposed amendments to the guidelines of the Assistance to Individuals in Crisis Situations (AICS).

**1.4 Schematic Diagram**





**1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study**

**Objectives of the Study**

This study aims to evaluate the reach and effectiveness of victim aid programs in rural areas.

1. )To describe how victim assistance programs are accessed and reached by individuals living in rural areas, based on the accounts of victims, community members, and service providers.

2. )To document the experiences of rural victims in engaging with available victim assistance programs, highlighting the conditions, challenges, and circumstances that influence program reachability.

3. )To describe stakeholders' perceptions of the effectiveness of victim assistance programs in addressing the needs, well-being, and recovery of victims in rural settings.

4. )To characterize the contextual, cultural, and institutional factors present in rural communities that shape the delivery and perceived adequacy of victim assistance programs.



**1.6 Definition of Terms**

**Victim Aid Program -** An organized package of services and interventions offered by government or non-government agencies to assist persons who have been victims of crime, abuse, or other types of victimization.

**Reachability** - The extent to which rural residents can get to or know about victim aid programs. Physical proximity, communication, awareness, and availability of transportation are some of the factors included.

**Rural Areas -** Geographical areas with low densities of people, minimal infrastructure, and sometimes limited access to basic services.

**Service Delivery -** The process or procedure by which victim support services are delivered to the target group.

**Barriers to Access -** Any physical, economic, social, or cultural barriers that hinder people from accessing or profiting from victim support services.

**Stakeholders -** Individuals and organizations implementing or impacted by the deployment of victim aid programs.

**Program Evaluation -** The methodical evaluation of the design, implementation, and results of a program.

**Outreach -** The methods adopted by organizations to inform and enroll potential beneficiaries in rural areas.

**Victimization -** The process or experience of being harmed, injured, or made to suffer by means of a crime or abuse.

# CHAPTER 2

# RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

## 2.1 Research Design

The Research will employ a descriptive qualitative research design. This design aims to describe and examine the accessibility and effectiveness of victim aid programs in rural areas (BueNasCAr). Using this design, the researchers will be able to gather qualitative information regarding the accessibility, implementation, and effectiveness of programs for victims of crimes and natural disasters. The descriptive methodology will enable the researchers to paint a true picture of the status exchange and measure the level of satisfaction among beneficiaries.

## 2.2 Research Materials and Methods

The Research will use Qualitative methods.

Qualitative data will be collected through interviews and focus group discussions with selected victims and community leaders responsible for victim assistance. The tools will be tested for validity by experts within the field, and piloting will be done to assess reliability as well as question clarity.

## 2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

The Research will be carried out in (BueNasCar), wherein victim assistance programs are being implemented. Said rural areas (BueNasCar) have limited accessibility to social services and



are isolated, which can potentially influence the extent of government or NGO assistance programs.

The target population of the Research includes

- Victims of crimes

The sample size will be determined through purposive sampling of the most important informants, such as those involved in the program for victims and residents. An aggregate of 15 respondents, five from each Municipality, will seek to provide adequate representation across different groups within the rural areas (BueNasCar).

**2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan**

**Interview Guide**

The research instrument was a self-designed interview guide to obtain direct, comprehensive, and qualitative insights from the study's participants. The first section gathered participants' profiles (age, sex, position/rank, and years in service) and included the post-group survey questions. Participants then provided brief responses to open-ended questions intended to elicit feedback on the themes that emerged from the study's adjectives.

**2.5 Research Ethical Standards**

This Research, "Analyzing how Reachable Victim Aid Programs are in Rural Areas," addressed several ethical concerns to ensure the study meets the required research integrity and participant protection standards.

**A. Rights of Confidentially Privacy**

The Research will ensure that the rights to identity and personal information of participants are kept strictly confidential. Any identifying data should be anonymized or coded to prevent the disclosure of sensitive information, particularly because the topic involves victims who may be vulnerable or at risk.

**B. Informed Consent**

The study ensures that all participants are fully informed about the purpose, scope, and procedures of the research study in which they are to participate. Researchers should ensure that consent is given voluntarily without coercion and that participants understand their right to withdraw at any point without penalty.

**C. Voluntary Participation**

The Participants of the study must participate voluntary. No individual should feel pressured or obligated to take part, especially in small rural settings where social influence or authority figures might unintentionally create pressure.

**D. Fair Selection of Participants**

The study's selection process should be equitable and free from discrimination. Participants should be selected based on the research objectives, ensuring that the study includes diverse voices within the rural area, including marginalized or underrepresented groups.

**E. Minimization of Harm**

The researchers were committed to the ethical conduct of the study, prioritizing the safety of respondents. The researchers have clearly communicated the informed consent to ensure respondents understand the purpose, methods, and risks of the Research. Participation was voluntary, with the right to withdraw at any time without penalty. Any information, pseudonyms, as well as secure systems from which only the research group can access, were used. Sensory-distressing questions were also avoided, as they could cause distress, but support services were made available in response to their needs.

**F. Intellectual Property Rights ( IPR )**

This Research respected intellectual property rights. No new technologies, processes, or products were developed and, therefore, have not required any patent protection. The Philippine copyright law (RA NO. 8293), the Intellectual Property Code, has protected all original materials produced as research instruments and data analysis tools. All literature or secondary data borrowed from third-party sources were cited correctly. Ensured respect for other people's intellectual property, but protects the researcher's intellectual property. In this case, since no

new brand, logo, or symbol was created, trademark registration was made impossible to apply for.

**G. Beneficence**

The study aims to make a positive contribution by identifying ways to enhance victim aid programs. Findings will be used to enhance accessibility and effectiveness rather than to exploit participants. The benefits of the Research should outweigh any potential risk.

**H. Data Integrity and Accuracy**

The researchers have modified the research questionnaire and have recognized potential biases, errors, and limitations. In this regard, the researchers have addressed this issue by conducting a thorough validity test. This process ensured that the revised questionnaire reflected both reliability and consistency with the study objectives, thus preventing issues with clarity, reliability, and consistency. The researchers have stated these in the final report and included potential biases from sampling, the questionnaire design, or the analytical technique. The respondents, with this level of detail, were allowed to evaluate whether such findings and their outcomes could be of use or detrimental.

**I. Transparency in Reporting**

The Research reported its findings comprehensively and honestly without compromising the collected data. Any external software or materials applied within the research methodology were credited to the actual authors, and this source list has been properly acknowledged to

recognize and pay respect to them. The authors of the study confirmed that they have no conflicts of interest regarding the Research. The researchers acknowledged the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools, such as ChatGPT, Grammarly, Quilbot, Cici, and HumanizeAI, which have aided them in various aspects of the Research.

### J. Use of Patented and Copyrighted Materials

The materials used in the Research were open-source software libraries, templates, and other educational resources, and were therefore used in accordance with the appropriate licensing agreements. The Resource Management System (RMS) was originally developed by Saint Michael College of Caraga, where the researchers are currently enrolled, so no patented technologies were used in developing this Research. However, patent protection might be pursued if the RMS seems to have commercial potential. The system has not included any unapproved content, ensuring it is copyright-compliant in both its implementation and design.

### K. Ethical Considerations for animals and human trials

Support services were made available by the researchers to the respondents of (BueNasCar), ensuring safety and prevention during an emergency. Informed consent was obtained through a clear explanation of the study's purpose, methods, and risks. Participation was strictly voluntary, with full rights to withdraw from participation at any time without penalty. Data confidentiality was assured through the use of pseudonyms and other security measures, limiting access. These measures were to ensure a respectful and ethical research environment. Since the researchers

used humans, not animals, as their respondents, ethical considerations for animals are not applicable.

### L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technologies

The Research incorporated AI tools and digital technologies that facilitated all stages of the Research. Grammarly has been employed to enhance grammar and clarity in the research report. AI tools like ChatGPT, Quillbot, and Humanizeai have helped organize ideas and summarize preliminary findings. Elicit, Google Scholar, and Research Gate were used to source secondary data or literature that supports the Research. These tools have been used responsibly, ensuring that their outputs were carefully reviewed and verified by the researchers to maintain accuracy and avoid introducing bias. The researchers acknowledged that AI tools are evolving, and their use in Research requires careful consideration and ethical oversight.

### M. Ethical Approval

The Research has been approved by the ethical review board of St. Michael's College of Caraga, which has affirmed compliance with all applicable policies regarding subject protection, data confidentiality, and intellectual property ownership.

